

TUX NEWS

✖✖ REV JAMES BEVEL ✖✖ Children's March

It's June Sixth, 1963. Thousands of Children Protest In The Streets, Lead by a Strategist in the Shadows. That Strategist was Rev. James Bevel.

How we can honor him:

James Bevel was a valuable strategist of the Civil Rights Movement, but he was also a child predator, who molested his daughter Aaralyn Mills. I propose we make a statue in front of the 16th Street Baptist Church building that looks like the image on the right. His good outweighs his bad, and he still deserves recognition for the good things he did

Obstacles

They faced problems with their numbers and enthusiasm. This made it difficult to gain momentum with a low number of people.

Opposition Groups created obstacles because they wanted to keep segregation and unequal rights.

Rev. James Bevel used his words, intelligence, and risk taking to support the movement. James used large crowds to fill the jail until they could negotiate terms with the city.

In Birmingham, a government institution (Police) used its power to target people based on their race. The victims had no voice and were treated as less than other citizens. Bevel responded by making the problem visible to the public, and demanding changes. Now, a government institution (I.C.E.) is accused of using its power to target people based on their ethnicity/race. The people targeted often have limited legal protection or voice. People today are responding by protesting, filming encounters, and demanding policy change. As you can probably tell, Both of these examples have very similar underlying principles.



Children's March

The event took place in
Birmingham, Alabama, on
May 2-10, 1963

Thousands of children
gathered at 16th Street
Baptist Church to protest
for their rights.

Organizations SCLC and
ACMHR worked with the
children's march.

It generated a lot of
sympathy, and was a
turning point of the
movement.

James Bevel

Rev. James Bevel was a civil rights activist and one of Martin Luther King Jr.'s most influential lieutenants in the SCLC. Born in Mississippi, Bevel was ordained as a Baptist minister in 1959 and received his Bachelor of Arts from American Baptist Theological Seminary in 1961. He was very committed to the idea that religion and the church should serve as institutions for social change. He was chairman of the Nashville Student Movement, a founding member of SNCC, and joined SCLC in 1961. He then became head of direct action and youth training specialist at SCLC. James Bevel grew up in Mississippi, with 16 siblings, in a sharecropping family. While studying at the American Baptist Theological Seminary, he became a leader of the Nashville Student Movement, where he was trained by Rev. James Lawson in Gandhi's principles. Civil Rights leaders John Lewis, Diane Nash, and Marion Barry. As a strong preacher, Bevel inspired many citizens to join the movement, convincing Fannie Lou Hamer to attempt voter registration.

He worked with Dr. Martin Luther King Jr., Bevel where he strategized three of SCLC's most significant achievements: the 1963 Birmingham Children's Crusade, the 1965 Selma voting rights movement, and the 1966 Chicago open housing movement. He was considered a leader or co-leader for most of the movements he was involved in.

He spent weeks developing the strategy and conducting training sessions at Birmingham's 16th Street Baptist Church, teaching students nonviolent philosophy and techniques. He directed the students in organized, peaceful marches, sending approximately 50 at a time to City Hall, to confront the Mayor about segregation. His actions improved the movement because he fixed their issue of declining support from adults, and his movements were successful

Throughout his civil rights journey, he faced large risks and challenges. He was arrested multiple times during Freedom Rides and participated in voting rights campaigns in the South where activists encountered violence. His work made him navigate opposition from authorities, one being President Kennedy's request to stop using children in demonstrations. Despite these problems, Bevel remained committed to nonviolent direct action.

He supported nonviolent protests, teaching people to avoid violence and helped stop riots sometimes. The people he worked with sometimes thought his ideas were strange, as they didn't agree with using children and didn't want him to contribute to child delinquency.